Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 24-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣ <minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
  . – any character
  * – zero or more
  + – one or more
  ? – zero or one / lazy match
  ^ – start of line / negation in class
  $ – end of line
  ( ) – capture group
  [ ] – character class
  { } – repetition count
  | – alternation
  \ – escape character itself
```

1.4 Launching

- `helix`
- `helix <file>`
- `helix <file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- `helix <directory>`
- `helix -help`
- `hx in some distributions or by alias`

1.5 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

```
v3wd – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree
                history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by
                step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
  <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
        Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
  :wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
  :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
   :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
  :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
 :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
      ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
            horizontal split
      ␣WF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
            vertical split
       gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url
            under selection.
      ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
      ␣F – open file picker at current working
            directory
      ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
  <enter> – open selected in current view
  Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
  Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
   :n – create new scratch buffer
  :bc – close current buffer
 :bca – close all buffers
 :bco – close all but current buffer
  :bn – next buffer
      ␣b – open buffer picker
      ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
      gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
      gn – go to next buffer
      gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
      ␣wq – close current split
      ␣wo – close all but current split
      ␣ww – next split
␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down /
            right
      ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
       Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
  zz, zc – align to center
      zt – align to top
      zb – align to bottom
      zm – align to middle horizontally
      zj – scroll down
      zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
   :tutor – open tutorial
       ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
  h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
     gh, gl – beginning of line
  <nn>gl – column <nn>
      gl – end of line
      gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
      ge – bottom of file
      gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to
           word
      g.– to last modification in current file
      gj – down textual line
      gk – up textual line
      gs – first non-white-space char
      gt – top of screen
      gc – middle of screen
      gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
  gd – go to definition
  gy – go to type definition
  gr – go to references
  gi – go to implementation

  ]d – next diagnostic
  [d – prior diagnostic
  ]D – last diagnostic
  [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  ]f, [f – to next, prior function
  ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
  ]T, [T – to next, prior test
  ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
  ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
  ]g, [g – to next, prior change
  ]G, [G – to last, first change

 Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
 Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
      % – select whole file
  Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
  Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at
          end)
  Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
  Alt-i – shrink selection
      ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:
          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m – closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
  w / W – to start of next word / WORD
  e / E – to end of current word / WORD
  b / B – to start of current word / WORD
      x – current line, extend by line
      X – extend to line
  Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
     ]p – to next paragraph
     [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
  Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
  Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
  Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
  Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
  Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
   Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
       v – toggle select mode
     Esc – return to normal
       ) – cycle primary selection forward
       ( – cycle primary selection backward
  Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
  s<regex> – matches become selections
         S – split on match
   Alt-s – split on newlines
C / Alt-C – add selection below / above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
       & – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
         ␣ – remove all except primary selection
   Alt-,  – remove primary selection
   ( / )  – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
         K – keep selections matching the regex
   Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
      i – before selection
      a – after selection
      I – at start of line
      A – at end of line
      o – add line and insert below cursor
      O – add line and insert above cursor
    Esc – end insert (return to normal)
      . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
     ]␣ – newline below
     [␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
      d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
   Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
      c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
   Alt-c – change, no save
      = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
  > – Indent line(s) containing selection
  < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
      ~ – change case
      ` – set lowercase
   Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         C – Toggle block comment
  ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
       J – join lines in a selection
   Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select
           the inserted space
  <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
   :sort – sort ranges in selection
 :format – format file using external formatter /
           language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
     ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
     ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selection(s)
     ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
     n, N – next, previous match
        * – search for current selection, respect word
            boundaries
   Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
  "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
     ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
      mm – go to matching delim
  mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
  ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
   Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
   Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command
          returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
  ␣G – debug - experimental
  ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
  ␣s – open document symbol picker
  ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
  ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
  ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
  ␣r – rename symbol
  ␣a – apply code action
  ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under
       cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
  :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config
                         file
  :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
  ␣' – open last picker
  ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder
       picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                 Ctrl-s – commit undo
                          checkpoint
                 Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                 Ctrl-r – insert a register
                          content
       Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
            Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                 Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                 Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
            Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
            Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line

  <Up>, <Down>, <Left>,– usual meaning but
     <Right>, <PageUp>,   discouraged
<PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
          Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
              <enter> – open selected
                  <tab> – select next completion item
            <backtab> – select previous completion item
                 Alt-b – backward a word
                 Ctrl-b – backward a char
                 Alt-f – forward a word
                 Ctrl-f – forward a char
                 Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                 Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
  Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                 Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                 Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
        <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
        <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                 Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor
                          (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w
                          later)
                 Ctrl-p – select previous history
                 Ctrl-n – select next history
                 Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register
                          selected by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
      Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
          <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                        <Home> – to first entry
                         <End> – to last entry
             Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
           Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                      <enter> – open selected
                <Alt-enter> – open selected in the
                              background without
                              closing the picker
                      Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                      Ctrl-v – open vertically
                      Ctrl-t – toggle preview
                  Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
  Ctrl-u – scroll up
  Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
  Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
        Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
            <enter> – close menu and accept completion
             Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
  Alt-p – previous signature
  Alt-n – next signature
```